

Getting the most out of a RACI chart

3 XP • Team Leadership and Performance Management

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In an earlier video, you learned how critical a **RACI chart** is for creating clear roles and giving direction to each team member on a project. In this reading, we will further explore the function and components of RACI charts and how to use them to communicate responsibilities to project teams.

Definition and structure

Determining who is **R**esponsible, **A**ccountable, **C**onsulted and **I**nformed on your projects allows you to keep control of the stakeholders roles on your project.

Step	Project initiation	Project executive	Project manager	Project analyst	Project architect	Application developers
1	Task 1	C	A/R	C	I	I
2	Task 2	A	I	R	C	I
3	Task 3	A	I	R	C	I
4	Task 4	C	A	R	R	I

Workload balance

Are there too many tasks assigned to one stakeholder? When you complete your chart, it is a good idea to go back through and tally the number of Rs assigned to each stakeholder. This can help you identify potentially overloading one team member with work. Using a RACI chart to determine responsibility for tasks can help mitigate single points of failure (known as creating **silos**, where the knowledge and responsibility for a task falls on one person) and allow you, as the project manager, to delegate tasks and avoid burnout. Maintaining workload balance is a critical part of project management. It is easy to fall into the pattern of relying on your top performers to keep the project moving forward. But this isn't always healthy for the project or your team. If you find that you don't have the right people to assign responsibilities to, take a step back and evaluate your team.

Put your RACI into practice

Once you have created your RACI chart, it is time to put it into practice. You will first need to share your RACI chart with your sponsors and stakeholders to get buy-in and sign-off. When you get stakeholder buy-in, you will be able to set clear expectations for your team and ensure that everyone is aligned on their responsibilities.

You can document your team and stakeholders' acknowledgment of these expectations through the project charter, meeting notes, and in the RACI chart itself. Think back to a time when you were expected to do something you did not agree with, or weren't clear on. That disagreement or lack of clarity made it difficult to do your best work, right? Getting buy-in and continually checking in with your stakeholders and your team is the way to avoid this potential pitfall!

As you take the time to ensure that each task has an owner identified with the appropriate level of engagement, you are streamlining your communication and decision-making process over the life cycle of your project.

When should you use a RACI chart?

If you are wondering if you should use a RACI chart on your project, it is a good idea to evaluate the complexity of the effort. For example, if you have a very small project team with a small number of stakeholders, clearly defined roles, and a short timeline, introducing a RACI chart could possibly slow down the project. However, larger projects, or even projects that involve a large number of stakeholders, could greatly benefit from a RACI chart. It is always a good idea to work through the creation of a RACI chart and evaluate the outcome. Even if you do not end up using the RACI chart, you will have a better understanding of the project, and your effort will contribute to your project management experience overall.